

Chicago Tribune



\$4.00 | MONDAY, AUGUST 24, 2026 | CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Most in Cook County to see higher tax bills

Property taxes rise again as nearly all agencies raise their levies, treasurer's analysis shows

By A.D. Quig
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Cook County property taxes are going up again for the vast majority of homeowners and business operators who will finally get their bills next month after another round of delays.

Of the 1.8 million bills set to hit mailboxes Sept. 1, about 1.3 million

residences and 100,000 businesses will see an increase, according to Cook County Treasurer Maria Pappas' annual analysis.

The total property tax bill for every city, town, school district and other taxing body across Cook County is more than \$19.9 billion — an increase of about \$744 million (or 3.9%) compared with last year. It's the 32nd straight annual

increase, according to the report.

Nearly all taxing agencies across the county raised their property tax levies this year, the analysis found. About 60% increased them by more than the 3.1% rate of inflation.

Of that new sum, homeowners will pay nearly \$600 million, while business properties like offices, factories and big apartment buildings will pay the rest.

The biggest changes will be felt in suburban communities north of North Avenue, who had their properties reassessed in 2025. Growth

in home values there “significantly outpaced” those for businesses, the report said, shifting 2% more of the region's overall tax burden onto homeowners.

Unlike the major spike last cycle that saw a historic 15.7% increase in median bills across the northern suburbs, the median tax bill for homeowners there climbed by 6.7% this year to \$8,007, per the analysis.

For multifamily buildings, the median bill went up by 3.5% to \$26,772. The median commercial building bill, meanwhile, dropped

by 3.5% to \$28,253. Rising property taxes in apartment and commercial buildings often translates to higher rents for tenants.

Commercial values — a category that includes office space, hotels and restaurants — declined in Chicago and grew slowly in the northern suburbs.

It's the fifth year in a row the higher tax burden has landed on homeowners as compared with business properties — office

See **TAXES** on Page A5

Edward Gardner, left, laughs with fellow teacher Lynda McGee as he prepares for the first day of classes at Burnham Math & Science Academy in Chicago on Friday. Gardner was promoted from a special education assistant to having his own classroom. **ANTONIO PEREZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

For a new special ed teacher, it's a 'dream come true'

By Darcel Rockett | CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Burnham Mathematics & Science Academy teachers and staff members were in full swing Friday morning, preparing for students' first day of the school year.

Kid-sized light blue and apple-green furniture sits in Edward Gardner IV's classroom, which also hosts a “calm corner” — cushy seating surrounding a large, flat, circular light that emits subdued colors, much like a peaceful campfire scene, to help children who may need to reset. Puzzles and games rest atop organizing drawers of orange, blue, and green. This is just part of Gardner's world. His sweatshirt matches the warm, sea blues sprinkled throughout his classroom.

After years as a special education classroom assistant, or SECA, Gardner was promoted to a special education teacher at Burnham, in South

Edward Gardner spent years as a classroom assistant before a teacher residency program helped him land the role he knows he was meant for at Chicago's Burnham elementary

Deering, helming a class of five students on the autism spectrum. Though his path as an educator was unconventional, Gardner said he always knew he'd be working with kids — mentoring, coaching, teaching.

“It's a childhood dream come true,” he said. “I have moments where I'm still like, ‘why me?’ But it quickly goes away. When you pick education, it picks you — you're really chosen for it.”

At age 11, Gardner was inspired by the late educator Joe Louis Clark, portrayed by Morgan Freeman in the film “Lean on Me.” Gardner remembers watching the film, in which Freeman's Principal Clark turns around a New Jersey school riddled with crime, drugs and low test scores. That was when he told his father and aunt he wanted to have the effect Freeman's character had on

See **TEACHER** on Page A5

Carney's prophecy a warning to others

Canada leader cited economic coercion by bigger countries

By Rob Gillies
ASSOCIATED PRESS

TORONTO — Mark Carney drew international attention as Canada's prime minister by warning that middle powers must resist economic coercion by more powerful countries. Now President Donald Trump is putting that warning to the test with sweeping new tariffs that could show how much economic pain Canada can absorb.

Tensions escalated late Friday when Canada walked away from negotiations after Carney concluded the United States was demanding too much in exchange for tariff relief.

The U.S. imposed 50% duties Saturday on about \$20 billion worth of Canadian goods, and Carney announced dollar-for-dollar retaliation beginning Sept. 8.

“We're going to hit back,” Carney said.

Carney is doing what many other American allies have so far avoided: risking economic pain rather than yielding to tariff pressure.

For Carney, the showdown is the clearest test yet of his argument that middle powers must stand up to economic pressure from great powers such as the United States and China, even when it comes at a cost.

Canada's response could show how countries navigate a world in which long-standing alliances offer less protection and economic ties themselves become sources of leverage.

It could also shape how Carney is viewed at home and abroad, and how other U.S. allies respond to the Republican president.

The trade dispute also has

See **CANADA** on Page A5

INSIDE

Indian celebration on Devon Avenue

Chicago's Indian Independence Day parade kicked off Sunday with the revving of motorcycles and the beating of drums in West Ridge. South Asian cultural groups joined in marking 80 years of Indian independence. **Chicagoland**

Iran head defends earlier agreement

Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian defended a June memorandum of understanding with the United States as the best way to move beyond a situation of “neither war nor peace.” **Nation & World**

Police superintendent search moves forward

Chicago agency retains hiring firm to screen applicants; official had pressed for more time

By Sam Charles
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

The search for the next leader of the Chicago Police Department entered a new phase last week as the city agency responsible for vetting candidates retained an executive search firm to winnow down future applicants.

Despite a plea from a police oversight commissioner to amend a city ordinance, Mayor Brandon Johnson is expected to have three finalists to choose from before Thanksgiving, just three months ahead of Chicago's next mayoral election.

The selection process — the

second to be headed by the Community Commission for Public Safety and Accountability — is unfolding as the city grapples with an unwelcome uptick in gun violence in the waning days of summer. Though the overall number of killings across the city has increased only slightly in 2026 — CPD recorded 271 homicides through Aug. 16, compared with 262 the year before — police data show a sharp rise in killings in a few South and West side neighborhoods that have long been afflicted by poverty and gun violence.

See **POLICE** on Page A2

Then-police Superintendent Larry Snelling listens as then-Chief of Detectives Antoinette Ursitti speaks at police headquarters on Aug. 1, 2024. **ANTONIO PEREZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

SUBSCRIPTION

Visit myaccount.chicagotribune.com or call 312-546-7900 to sign up for a subscription. To place an ad, visit placeanad.chicagotribune.com.

WEATHER FORECAST

TODAY H: 78 L: 59
TUE. H: 80 L: 64
WED. H: 81 L: 65
Complete details on Page A12

INDEX

Almanac A2
Arts & Living B5
Comics B8-9
Crossword B9
Editorials A6
Horoscope B8
Nation & World B1
Obituaries A9
Television B7

179th year No. 236
© Chicago Tribune